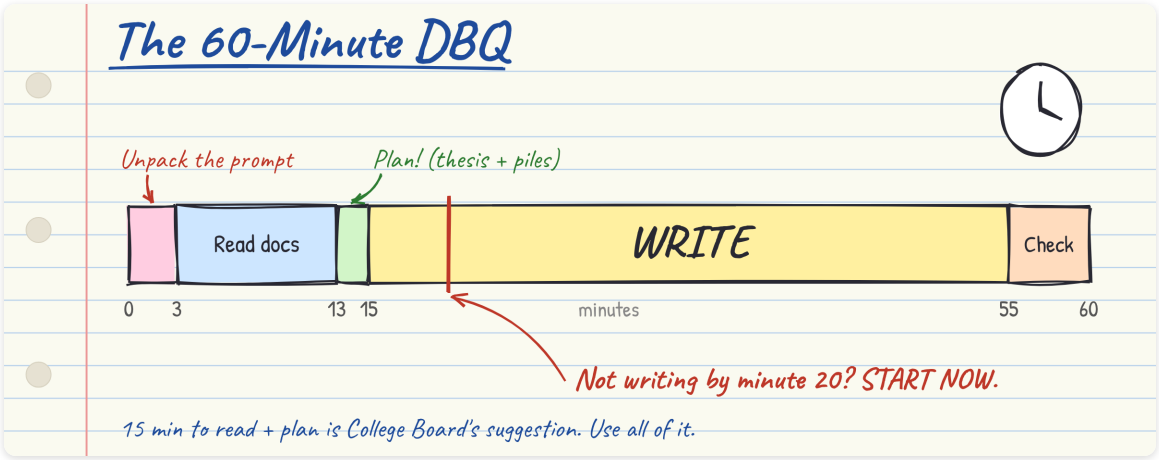
DBQ Strategy Cheat Sheet

Oct 29, 2026 · @CJ DeRuyter

The strategies that win DBQ points without being rubric points themselves: how to spend 60 minutes, read the prompt and documents, plan, and build the essay. For what earns each point, see the DBQ Point Guides.

The 60-minute plan

The DBQ gets 60 minutes, and College Board recommends spending the first 15 reading and planning. Students who plan start writing with a structure; students who don't run out of time in the middle of the second body paragraph.



Minutes	Phase	What gets done
0–3	Unpack the prompt	Dates, category, skill, task marked
3–13	Read the documents	Source line first, one-line gist per doc, group label per doc
13–15	Plan	Thesis drafted, 2–3 body categories, docs assigned, sourcing and outside evidence chosen
15–55	Write	Intro, 2–3 body paragraphs, optional short conclusion
55–60	Check	Run the final check at the bottom of this page

Rule of thumb: if the first body paragraph isn't started by minute 20, cut the plan short and write. A planned essay with two body paragraphs beats an unfinished one with three.

Unpack the prompt

An essay that answers a slightly different question loses almost every point, however good the writing. Mark up the prompt before touching the documents:

1. **Translate the task.** "Evaluate the extent to which" = *how much?* Your answer is a degree: greatly, partly, little. "Evaluate the relative importance" = *rank them*.
2. **Box the dates.** Write centuries as years ("19th century" → 1800s). Everything you argue must fall inside them; context can sit just outside.
3. **Underline the category.** Society, economy, politics, culture, foreign policy. If it says *society*, a political event only counts once you show its social effect.
4. **Name the skill.** Causation (cause, led to, effect), continuity and change (changed, extent of change), or comparison (similarities, differences). If none is stated, pick one and stay with it.
5. **Count the parts.** Some prompts ask two questions. The Cold War prompt asks both *how great were the fears* and *how effective was the government's response*; the thesis must answer both.

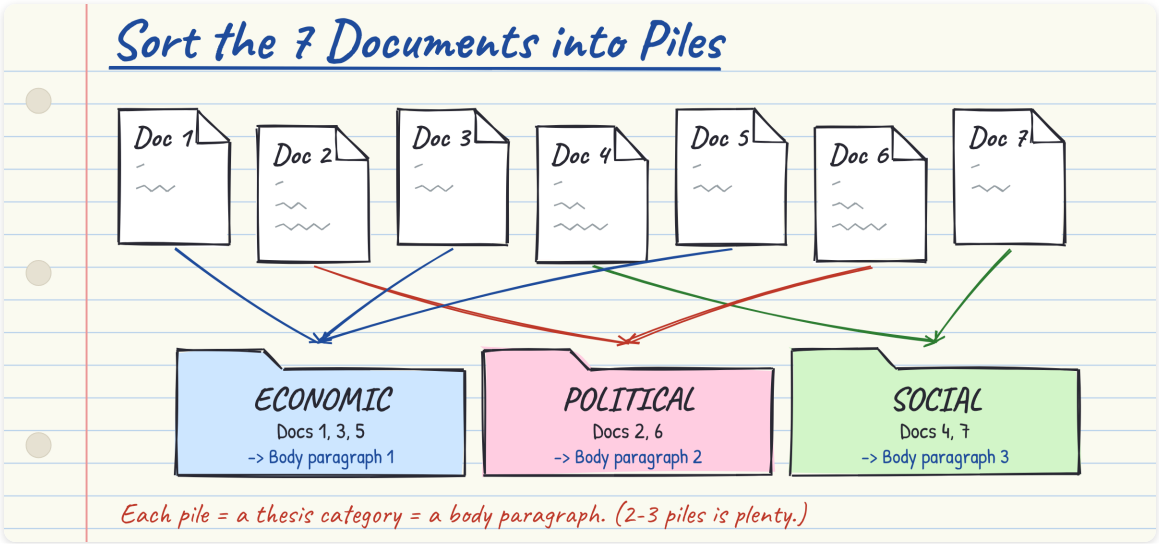
Social vs. cultural, a common mix-up: social = how people organize society (class, race, gender, family); cultural = beliefs, religion, art, ideas.

Read and group the documents

About a minute or two per document. For each one, write three things in the margin:

1. **Source line first.** Who, when, what kind of source. Often it tells you the author's side before you read a word, and it hands you sourcing material for free.
2. **A 5–10 word gist** in your own words. If you can't write one, re-read once, then move on.
3. **A group label.** Economic / political / social, or *fear increased* / *fear reduced*, or *for* / *against*. Aim for 2–3 groups.

Why grouping matters: the exam writers chose the seven documents to fall into groups. Finding the groups gives you your thesis categories and your body paragraphs, and keeps you out of the "Document 1 says… Document 2 says…" trap.



Also jot, while reading:

- **One HIPP note** next to any document whose source line is rich (a speech to Congress, an activist, a famous date).
- **Outside evidence the document reminds you of** (a law, person, or event *not* in any document).
- **A star** on any document that complicates your likely argument. That's your counterargument and complexity material.

Images: read the title, caption, date, and creator first; then describe what is shown and what the creator wants the viewer to feel.

Plan before writing

Two minutes of planning saves ten of wandering. Fill a quick grid, one row per body paragraph:

Body paragraph claim	Documents	Source which? (HIPP)	Outside evidence

Then check the plan against the scoring targets before writing a word:

- ☐ Every document is placed somewhere (aim for all 7; never fewer than 4)
- ☐ 3 documents marked for sourcing (2 required, 1 spare)
- ☐ 2 outside examples, neither used for context
- ☐ One paragraph or part of a paragraph that argues the other side
- ☐ Thesis written out in full at the top of the plan

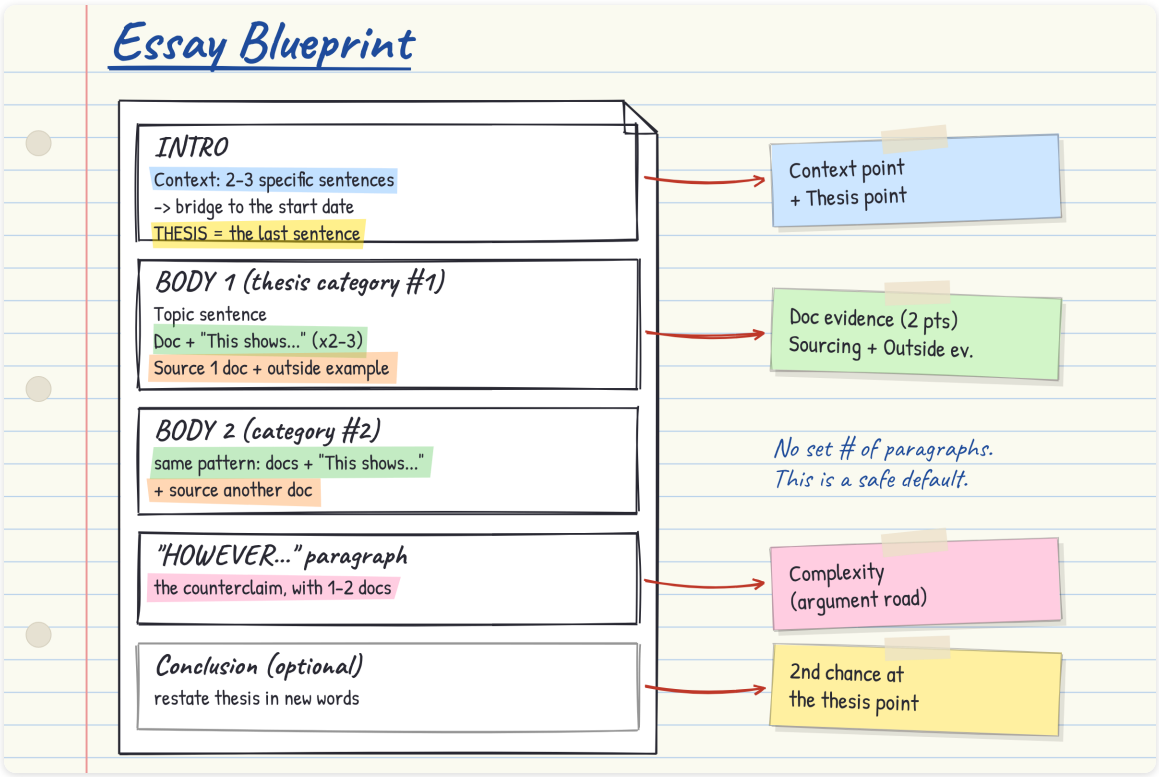
Cold War example plan (one possible argument; written for this cheat sheet):

Body paragraph claim	Documents	Source which?	Outside evidence
Fear of communism spreading abroad was intense, so the government acted overseas	B, E	B (situation: Guatemala coup), E (audience: Americans and the Soviets)	Truman Doctrine; Korean War
The government reassured Americans by building strength at home	D, G	G (purpose: win funding by calling it security)	Sputnik and NASA
However, government action also deepened fear	A, plus C and F once the images are read	A (POV: Republican president criticizing his party's investigators)	McCarthy and the Army-McCarthy hearings

Thesis drafted from this plan: "Although programs like the interstate highways and federal science education reassured Americans that the nation was prepared, Cold War fears stayed high after 1945 because the arms race and anticommunist investigations kept nuclear war and subversion in daily life."

Essay blueprint

The rubric requires no set number of paragraphs and no conclusion. This structure is a safe default that puts every point where a reader expects it.



1. **Introduction (4–6 sentences)**
   - 2–3 sentences of context: specific events before the prompt's dates that set up its topic.
   - 1 bridge sentence to the prompt's start date.
   - The thesis as the last sentence(s): counterclaim + position on *how much* + 2–3 categories.
2. **Body paragraphs (2–3, one per thesis category)**
   - **Topic sentence** lifted from one thesis category.
   - For each document: describe it in your own words → "This shows…" tied to the topic sentence.
   - Source one document in the paragraph: "Because [H/A/P], [author's] purpose was…, which shows…"
   - Add one outside example: name it, explain it, connect it.
   - **Closing sentence** that answers "so what?" for the thesis.
3. **The "However" paragraph (or a turn inside the last body paragraph)**
   - Argue the counterclaim from the thesis with 1–2 documents, then explain how it limits or qualifies the main argument.
4. **Conclusion (optional, 2–3 sentences)**
   - Restate the thesis in new words. It's a second chance at the thesis point if the intro version was weak.
   - Optional: a developed comparison to another era, if there's time.

Writing habits that protect points

- **Argue, don't report.** Every paragraph should be making a claim the documents prove. A reader should be able to disagree with your topic sentences.
- **Paraphrase, don't quote.** Quote a few words at most, inside your own sentence. A quote standing alone earns nothing.
- **Label documents** ("Document E" or "Kennedy's inaugural, Doc E") so the reader can credit each one.
- **Use signal phrases** that show the reader your moves: "This shows…", "Because Eisenhower was speaking to Congress…", "Another example beyond the documents is…", "However…"
- **Be specific.** Names, dates, laws, and places beat "people," "the government," and "back then" every time.
- **Write only what earns points.** College Board's credited examples are often one or two sentences. Long background paragraphs cost time without adding points.
- **Write legibly.** Readers can't credit what they can't read. Skip lines if your handwriting is small.
- **Don't panic about errors.** Readers treat the essay as a first draft. Grammar and small factual slips don't cost points unless they undercut the argument.

Common traps

Trap	What it looks like	The fix
The laundry list	"Document 1 says… Document 2 says…" in order	Group documents by argument; each paragraph makes one claim
Wrong time period	Writing about the First Great Awakening for a Second Great Awakening prompt	Box the dates; check every example against them
Wrong skill	Arguing causes when the prompt asks for effects	Name the skill before reading the documents
Half the prompt	Answering "how great were the fears" but not "how effective was the response"	Count the parts of the prompt; the thesis must answer each
Context that wanders	A Progressive Era essay that opens with Manifest Destiny	Context must explain the prompt's *topic*, not just its era
Misread document	Saying an author supports the opposite of what they argue	Write the gist from the source line + text before using it
The orphan counterclaim	"Although some disagree…" in the thesis, never mentioned again	Give the counterclaim its own paragraph or turn
Double-dipping	Using the same fact for context and outside evidence	Keep two separate outside examples ready
Running out of time	Two strong paragraphs, the third cut off mid-sentence	Follow the clock; finish each paragraph before starting the next

Final check (last 5 minutes)

Run down the list; fix the first thing that's missing, then the next.

- ☐ Thesis answers every part of the prompt with a position and a "because"
- ☐ Context is 2+ specific sentences tied to the prompt's topic
- ☐ At least 4 documents described in my own words, each followed by "This shows…"
- ☐ At least 2 documents sourced, each with "which shows / that matters because…"
- ☐ One outside example, named, explained, connected, and inside the dates
- ☐ A counterclaim or second perspective developed with evidence
- ☐ No document misread; every example inside the time period
- ☐ Short of time? Add a one-sentence conclusion restating the thesis, and source one more document in a single sentence

Sources for these strategies: College Board 2023–2025 DBQ scoring guidelines and sample commentaries, and Heimler's History videos (THREE Secrets to a Perfect DBQ, A FORMULA for Writing a DBQ, How to Understand ANY DBQ Prompt, How to WRITE DBQs Faster, Top 5 MISTAKES from the AP Readers).